

Technical SEO

Crawlability, indexing controls, sitemaps and structured data

robots.txt

- Lives at the domain root.
- Blocks crawling, not indexing.
- Never block CSS or JavaScript Google needs to render pages.

XML sitemaps

- Only canonical, indexable, 200-status URLs.
- Submit in Search Console.
- Reference it in robots.txt with a Sitemap: line.

Structured data

- Use JSON-LD with schema.org types.
- Mark up only visible content.
- Validate with the Rich Results Test.

noindex, canonicals and redirects

- noindex: keep out of results.
- canonical: choose the preferred duplicate.
- 301: permanent move; update internal links too.

HTTPS, status codes and site architecture

- Serve every page over HTTPS.
- Fix 5xx errors quickly.
- Keep key pages within three clicks of the homepage.

Which control to use

Goal	Use	Do not use
Keep a page out of search results	noindex	robots.txt Disallow
Stop bots crawling an infinite filter	robots.txt Disallow	noindex on millions of URLs
Consolidate duplicate URLs	rel="canonical"	Deleting pages without redirects
Page moved permanently	301 redirect	302 temporary redirect

HTTP status codes for SEO

Code	Meaning	SEO effect
200	OK	Page can be indexed
301	Moved permanently	Signals passed to the new URL
404 / 410	Not found / gone	Dropped from the index over time
503	Service unavailable	Tells Google to retry later during maintenance

Remember

- robots.txt manages crawling; noindex manages indexing.
- Sitemaps should contain only URLs you want indexed.
- Structured data creates eligibility for rich results, not a guarantee.

Watch: Technical SEO Best Practices for Beginners — Ahrefs (SEO Course, lesson 4.2) — <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=RFIpwKQ0bEs>